

The Second Noble Truth — The Wheel of Dependent Origination

Bhante Bodhidhamma · A Foundation Course in Buddhism · 19:20

Foundation Course One, Talk Five: The Second Noble Truth - The Wheel of Dependent Origination

There came a time in the Buddha's life in late middle age when he decided to appoint one of his monks as a permanent attendant, and he asked Ānanda, a cousin, to be that person. Ānanda agreed to do so, but only on condition that he could hear every word the Buddha spoke, and if he were to miss any talks, the Buddha would relate to him what he had said. The Buddha agreed.

When the Buddha died, a great council was held to bring together all the discourses and make a compilation. It was this very same Ānanda who came to be relied upon to supply the discourses. He seems to have had quite a phenomenal audio memory, lucky in an oral tradition which was to hand down these discourses by rote learning for 500 years before they were finally committed to paper. So it is that all the discourses are prefaced, "Thus have I heard," and then there follows the place and occasion for the discourse.

On this particular occasion, it is this same Ānanda who tells the Buddha that although the teaching on the wheel of dependent origination is deep and profound, yet he, Ānanda, found it to be self-evident and fathomable. The Buddha rebukes him: "Don't say that, Ānanda, don't say it. This teaching of mine, the wheel of dependent origination, is not only profound and deep, it also bears the signs of being so." Then the Buddha goes on to say that it is because people have not grasped this that their lives continue to be miserable.

In a way, the teaching on the Wheel of Dependent Origination is the centrepiece of the Buddha's doctrine. It encapsulates not only the Four Noble Truths, but the whole of Buddhist psychology. It is an explanation of how we come to suffer and why we do so. It describes this in detail.

Of late, there was a renowned teacher in Burma, the Mogok Sayadaw, believed to be an Arahant, a Buddhist saint, who taught everything through this doctrine. Although the formulation of the Four Noble Truths came first during the reflections after the Enlightenment, it is said that after a period of seven days following the Enlightenment, the whole formula of the wheel came to the Buddha as he emerged from concentration in the early night, and that later he understood it in reverse order.

Here we can only hope to get a general idea of this teaching. We shall look at it as a day-to-day psychology and how it helps us to understand the meditation we do and how it can help us in daily life. For the

Buddha's teaching is not some empty descriptive philosophy. It's a theory we must prove to be true for ourselves by putting it into practice, by trying it out.

The first link, which is not to be considered a first cause but an underlying precondition out of which all our suffering, and indeed our existence, arises, is ignorance. Ignorance here means not knowing, just as I might not know your name simply because I've not heard it. This not knowing produces wrong understanding about life, delusions in fact. These delusions are inbuilt in our psychology. These delusions cause us to make decisions and act in certain ways which are unskillful and bring about unwholesome results.

It is in this way that mind is conditioned. Our mental life, our psychology, is full of habits which have been produced by our own decision-making, our wills. However, because our wills have acted upon wrong information, those delusions of ours, so the mind ends up with unskillful or unwholesome conditions, which in turn causes further suffering.

When I am a child, because I don't know any better, because I am ignorant, I accept what is given to me. If, for instance, I am told that people of other religions are evil and to be avoided, at first I believe it. This wrong understanding now produces an attitude, which in turn produces words and actions of particular behaviour whenever I should meet such people. I have internalised my parents' prejudice. An interesting word: prejudice. To form an opinion about something before the facts are known.

Deluded by this prejudice, I'm on my guard. I feel fear. These people are evil. I must get away before they do me harm. Or worse: if only we could be rid of them. Upon these thoughts, I avoid them. The important point to understand here is that although I have received a prejudice from my parents, and although I have been taught an attitude, in the final analysis, I make the decision to act upon it. In this way, I reinforce it so that it now becomes my prejudice.

All these decisions, acts of will, build up in the child's mind until the way I behave with people of other religions will be simply a blind conditional response. I may even have forgotten the reasons why I behave like that. In fact, to the child become an adult, such behaviour comes to be accepted as perfectly proper and self-evidently righteous.

So if we take any point of our lives, say when we wake up, we bring with us from the past all our ignorance and our delusive conditionings, the mental habits we've developed. Upon this twin base of ignorance and conditioned mental states, we perform all our activities.

As soon as we wake, the next five links on the wheel come into being. The first is consciousness itself, just that faculty in the mind that knows. With this arises all the rest of the mind: the mental aggregates of sensations, perceptions, and volitional conditionings, and at the same time, the body itself. Because of this mind and body, the six senses are activated, the sixth sense being the mind itself as a sense base receiving information from the other five senses. Because of these senses, contact is made with the world out there.

When this contact is made, feelings arise we experience as pleasant, unpleasant or neutral.

Here then is the human being as a receiver of information: the consciousness, the mental faculties and the body, the sense bases, contact with the world through these senses, and feelings caused by these contacts. Again, it is important to remember that everything has arisen because of something else. The human being comes into life at every moment of life in this way. Even in deep sleep there is some form of consciousness and sense contact, or how else could we pull a blanket over us when cold?

This moment is a product of all the past and contains in it the effects of all our yesterday's decisions, skillful and unskillful. Some are realised, others lie potential in that moment, to be realised at some future time.

To look at it another way, as soon as I see an apple, the first light that strikes the retina, the sense base, is the contact. Upon the contact feeling arises. I know this feeling, I am conscious of it. All this has happened by way of the physical and mental properties. In other words, the whole process is dependent, one thing on another, hence the wheel of dependent origination. Perhaps it would be better called interdependent origination since all these functions, properties, interrelate and work one upon the other.

However, this is not the end of the story. There are yet more links. In the previous five links, ignorance has been the latent factor affecting all our perception of things, the way we understand. It is the next link where the ignorance factor comes again more obviously into play.

As soon as pleasurable feelings are experienced, because of our past deluded conditioning, desire for them arises. As soon as desire has arisen, there is a strengthening of it, if the wheel is to progress onto craving, grasping, even obsession. Once this has happened, the will comes into play, and the desire is realised, activated, satisfied.

If we return to my apple, as soon as I saw the apple, there arose in me pleasurable feelings conditioned by past apple-eating. As soon as this happened, desire for more of those pleasurable feelings – not the apple itself, notice – arose in me. This desire takes hold of my mind in the form of grasping and craving. Before I know it, I've made the decision to eat it. When I actually eat the apple, I become the eater of the apple. I become absorbed in it, lost in it, totally self-identified with it. This is becoming. This is what Buddhism means by *kamma*. Kamma is simply becoming, being my actions, whether verbal or physical, and it is all brought about through my own will.

What about aversion and hatred? Here, it is simply seen as a type of desire. If, for instance, I don't like apples, my conditioned response may be to ignore it – that is, not wanting, not wishing to see it. If I had a disgust for it, I might throw it away in the bin. My desire is to remove it. Aversion and hatred are simply the obverse of desire: I want it, I don't want it. It's all want. It's all a matter of desire. Fear is also desire, in this case, the desire to remove myself. If I had a phobia of apples, I might shrink away when I see one or run off.

If they are neutral feelings, we usually remain ignorant of them, such as the sensations of our breathing process. Here, I'm using the word sensations and feelings to mean the same thing. What separates them into pleasant, unpleasant and neutral is our perception of them, how we name or label these sensations through our past experience.

The wheel has not yet finished turning. Having made visual contact with the apple, felt all the attendant sensations of delight, and knowing this, having reacted with desire and craving, I eat it. Now, of course, I've finished. I've eaten the apple. It took a little time, but I saw the apple coming to an end, my sensual pleasure coming to an end. Suddenly I'm left with just a core and a few pips. The apple is no more, and my delight is gone. These are the last two links. Having decided to do something, I am born into that action. This birth is the becoming, is the *kamma*. It is in this way that we are reborn from moment to moment. But as soon as I am born, born again, reborn into something, that thing must come by way of a decaying or a declining process to an end, at some time or other. Everything decays and dies.

However, in the process, I have also reinforced my conditioning, those volitional conditionings that sit as potential in my mind. I shall react very much the same when I next see an apple, and the wheel of dependent origination will turn yet again.

This is an explanation of the whole of moral human behaviour. Although this is a harmless example of apple eating, it's the same psychology that produces negative habits of smoking, alcoholism, sexual deviancy, crimes of violence, murder, and the same that causes selfishness and egotism to enter into the acts of love and compassion.

If a young teenage boy continually bombarded with sexual images uses the medium of sex to develop feelings of hate and the pleasures of cruelty, is it any wonder that sooner or later there's a rape?

Indeed, this wheel can be formulated in a slightly different way that brings this personality development more into relief. It is taught in Buddhism that upon the arising of a thought, there is an action. A thought here includes all the underlying ignorant delusion, the basic human faculties of body and mind needed to bring this about, and the deluded desires. Action is that point of decision which is an act of will. Upon a set of actions, a habit is established.

So we see that if we turn the wheel in a certain direction often enough, it will keep turning that way. It gathers momentum. Habits are hard to break. Long-established habits, harder still. Now a collection of habits is a personality. That's worth pondering on. A personality in Buddhism is just a whole collection of conditioned responses. This is not to say that humans are automatons. For remember, we condition ourselves. It's when we don't know this or forget this that we lose the ability to direct our lives. And so it is that this personality determines our destiny.

How important it is to become aware of our thoughts. If you were to say to an ordinary person in the street, what's worse: the thought of murder, the threatening of murder, or the action of murder? The

answer would be the action itself, since up to that time no actual harm had been done. And indeed, from the victim's and society's point of view, this is quite right. But from a mental process point of view and the murderer's point of view, the most important was the thought. For without the thought, the action would never have arisen, nor indeed the threatening.

From our point of view as meditators, this is something we have to grasp very deeply indeed, if we're eventually to escape this wheel of dependent origination, this wheel of suffering. In longer periods of meditation practice, such as a weekend or a week-long course, this process becomes more obvious to us. And with the practice of moment-to-moment awareness in our daily life, we can begin to catch this process and see how it's doing us harm, and more important, see how we can stop it.

So how do we undermine this wheel? First of all, we have to accept that all the links up to feeling – that is, all the ignorance, volitional conditionings, consciousness, mind and body, the six senses, contact, and the feelings that arise – are a given. They are conditioned. We can do nothing about those thoughts arising in the mind. They will come of their own.

Let me return to the problem of religious prejudice, which, sad to say, is very much a world phenomenon. Now because of this conditioning, when I come to know a person who is of a different religion to me, unpleasant, perhaps hateful thoughts and feelings arise. This is my conditioning, prejudicial, caused by a combination of my upbringing and my own past acts of will. It's a combination of my believing misinformation and acting upon it. But at this moment, when I see this other person, there is no act of will. I am not actively prejudicial. Upon the seeing there arises a conditioned response. There is nothing in the world I can do to stop that arising.

It is in the next links that this conditioned prejudice, already arisen in my mind, is acted upon. It is at the actual point of reaction – the desire, the craving and the action or becoming – where the choice arises to develop, reinforce these prejudicial conditionings or to let them go, to just observe them. If I decide to act upon them, to obey their suggestions, then I will strengthen my religious prejudice. I will feed it, develop it. But if I refuse to do so, if I just observe them, let them go, fail to obey them, I undermine that conditioning. For that conditioning needs my continued, active, willful support to grow, to develop, to sustain.

More, in deciding and willing not to act upon their suggestions, I set up a more wholesome conditioning of positive values. I am creating a new response, a new conditioning, which not only counteracts and undermines the old negative one, but is also producing something new. In short, initial thoughts and feelings are products of past action and conditioning. It is what I do with them that matters.

Now you will have noticed that I've used the concepts of wholesome and unwholesome. Indeed, this is Buddhist training. It is to begin to recognise what is unwholesome, harmful for ourselves and other beings, and to refuse to develop any further those very conditionings. Secondly, it is to foster within ourselves and to develop thoughts and feelings that are beneficial, wholesome. In this way we purify the

mind. In this way we are slowing down, wearing out the wheels. So long as we react to and indulge in unwholesome states of mind, so long are we deepening our ignorance and so worsening our suffering.

When we begin to let go of unwholesome states of mind and develop wholesome states of mind, we rid ourselves of ignorance. As we begin to rid ourselves of ignorance, the mind, clear of its obscuring wrong attitudes, opinions and prejudices, becomes more and more insightful until it can begin to plumb the depths of our being and see what it is we really are. This seeing ourselves as we really are, beyond greed, hatred and delusion, is the nirvanic experience.

Every time we undermine an unwholesome conditioning, we come to understand more deeply the insights the Buddha had on the night when he discovered the wheel of dependent origination in its reverse order. Indeed, as ignorance is destroyed, so are all the links on the chain, one upon the other, and with it goes our suffering. This doesn't mean annihilation. The Buddha continued to live another 45 years after his enlightenment, but in perfect peace and joy. When he was asked what happened to a Buddha, or a totally purified one upon death, his answer was that it was simply ineffable, not describable. *Parinibbāna* is beyond the wheel of becoming, the wheel of dependent origination.

So this is our task: to recognise unwholesome conditioning, thoughts and feelings for what they are. Let them go. We have to train ourselves in more wholesome ways of thinking and feeling.

We can do this. This is our freedom. We have the power, through our own wills, to change our states of mind. In meditation we see these conditionings, these states of mind, these emotions and moods, just as passing things, transient phenomena. We mustn't attach to them. We mustn't identify with them. And so too in daily life, while going about our day-to-day activities.

In this way our lives will become happier, more peaceful. When all conditions ripen, wholesome conditions, insight will arise naturally into that state beyond change. Nibbāna is assured.

Well, I hope you found this talk interesting and helpful. May all of you be happy and peaceful. May all of you attain the Nibbānic peace within.

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